

Finishing Out The Clark Range

When: September 1st to 3rd, 2012

Where: Yosemite, Chiquito Pass trailhead

Who: Matthew Hengst, Jack Kieffer, Jen Blackie, Jeff Atijera, Agustin Barajas

Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157631405385972/>

GPS Track: http://farm9.staticflickr.com/8171/7930854808_c6c564ce41_o.jpg

So after the previous weekends WTC experience trip I was pretty much moving forward with the assumption that whatever had kept me practically bed bound for two months was behind me. That meant it was time to salvage what was left of the summer and try to get ready for my rapidly approaching E provisional in Utah.

Jack and I had been working on clearing out the four Sierra Peaks Section peaks that making up the Clark range in Yosemite for a few years now.

The first try was October of 2010 when we missed our weather window by 1 day and a storm brought winter to Yosemite with a vengeance.



We retreated at the start of the rock section a few hundred feet below the summit due to snow and ice coating everything and enjoyed several days of solid rain on the way out.

Then in 2011 we went out in July hoping to do a 4 day that would hit Clark, Grey, and then run over to Ottoway Lakes to get Red and Merced.



No snow or rain this time but the record high snow year meant all the river crossings were...interesting.



We ended up getting Clark and Grey day two in a long 15 hour day then woke up pre dawn to hike over to Red and Merced.



Sadly the flooding made what would have been a long hard day all but impossible. We did make the lakes 11 miles later after numerous reroutes due to flooded streams and ended up retreating to camp promising we'd be back the following year.

So 2012 rolled around and Jack and I planned a run out to Ottoway Lakes to get those last two peaks.



Besides Jack and myself Augustine was back from last year and Jeff and Jen were joining us in the area for the first time.

As opposed to last year we had so little water this time we had to watch where we could fill up along the 16 mile hike in.



We came in via Chiquito Pass trailhead mostly because I'd never been in that way. We could have cut off a few miles by using the nearby Quartz Mountain trailhead at the cost of needing 4WD vehicles but what fun is that.



Meadows!



Forests!



16 miles with a big pack!



Eventually we strolled / limped in to Ottoway Lake with plenty of time to set up camp and had a relaxed dinner / happy hour.



We managed to turn in fairly early to make up for the lack of sleep the previous night.



Jack and I kicked everyone in to motion pre dawn and we started hiking by 6:30 am.





From camp we headed up the Ottoway Lakes drainage planning to climb up to the western ridge of Merced.



To the right was an easy enough 2nd class route but what fun was that. Jack and I took the group up through the rocks to the left.



Slightly more fun.

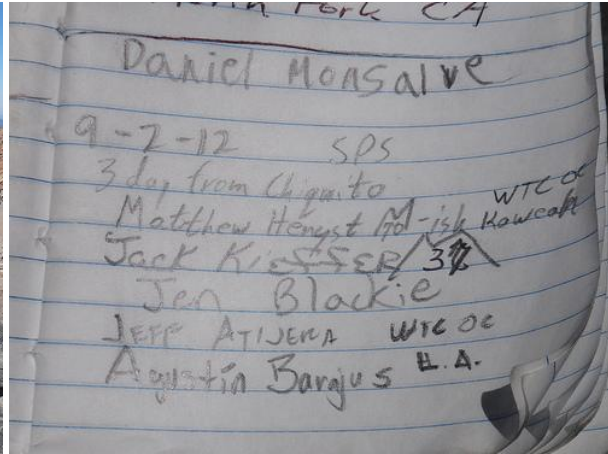
Once on the ridge we headed west towards the summit of Merced.



It started out a simple stroll but eventually got a bit of interesting 3rd class.



Without major difficulty we made the peak.



One down one (SPS) peak to go. From here we had to decide if we had the time and energy to do the nearby unlisted Triple Divide.



In addition to the fact the peak looked rather uninteresting I was worried about how fast we'd be since this was my first mjoor trip out post illness. The detour would have cost us several hours and made it quite possible we wouldn't make Red.

So instead we set off along the ridge stretching from Merced to Red.



We had nice views down towards our lake and its higher altitude companions.



Over the next few hours Red grew steadily closer but it was rather slow going.



We eventually climbed over a bump and found ourselves looking down on Red Pass.



We even had someone show up to talk to.

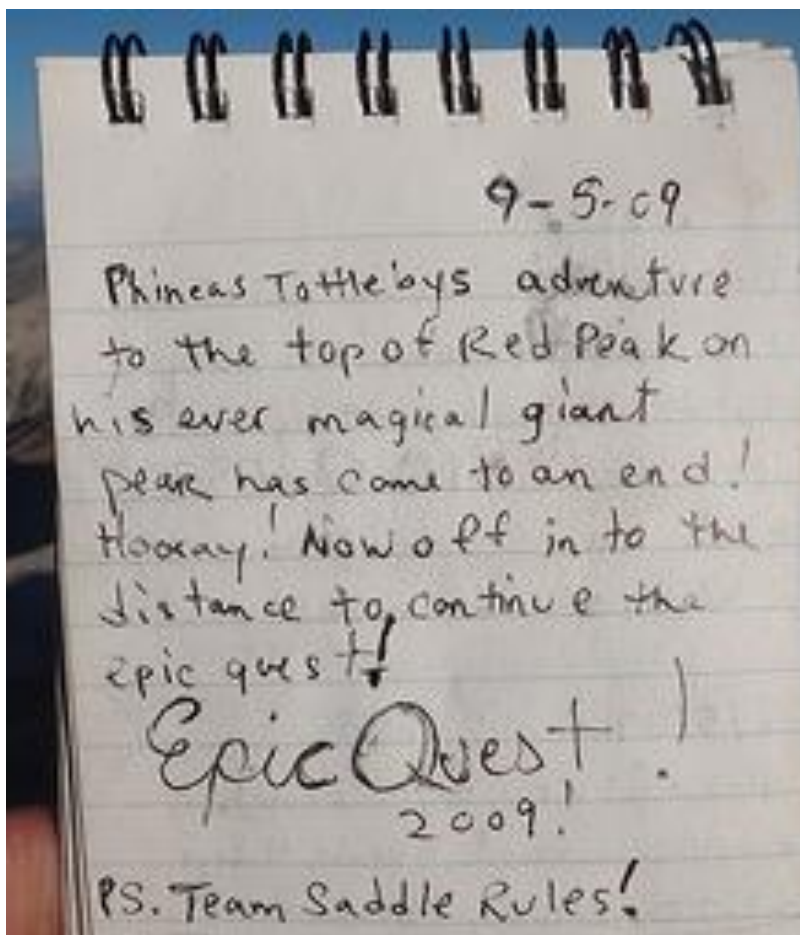


He was in the middle of an 11 day backpack and had a rather awesome beard. After a short chat we set off further down the ridge towards Red Peak.



On the map it looks like it's a simple stroll up a short elbow of the ridge. The reality involves a few more steep talus fields.

Some amount of unpleasantness latter we popped up on the summit ridge and bagged our peak.



Summit registers can be interesting...



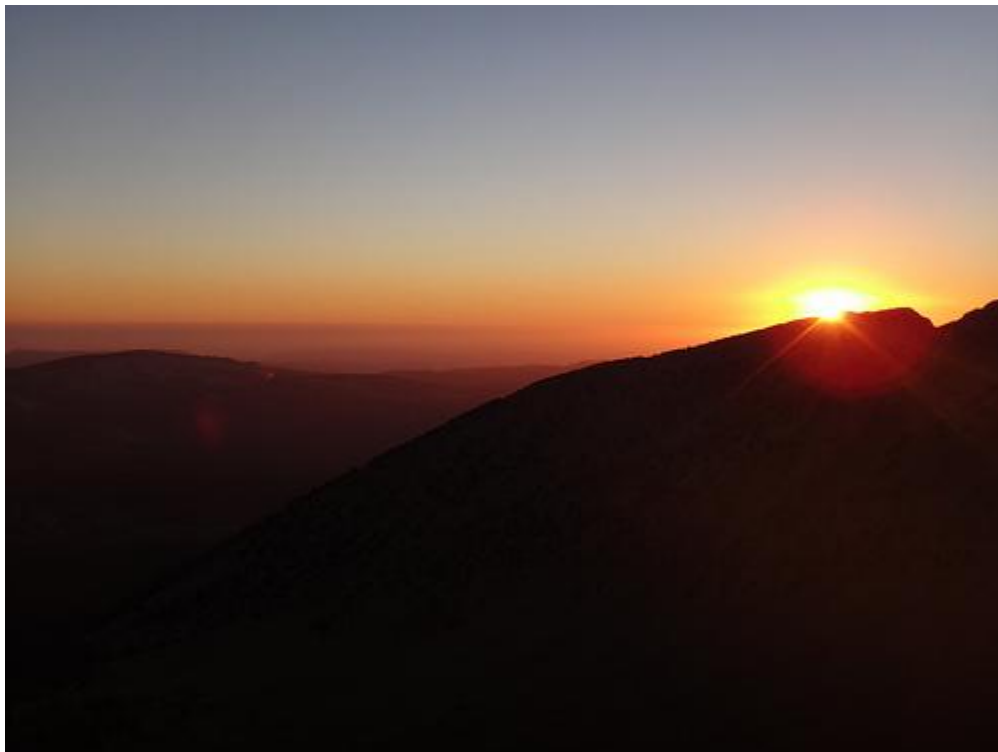
We signed in, had a bite to eat, and decided to continue down the end of the ridge and drop directly back to the lack instead of retracing our steps to the trail at Red Pass.



The view up top was rather nice.



We lost the sun part way down and continued via headlamp. Other than a few short sections that were so steep anything knocked loose would continue flying down into the darkness below it was largely uneventful.



Unstable boulders eventually gave way to vegetation and a flowing stream below and we eventually made camp around 9:30 pm.



Despite the long hike out the following day Jack and I decided to be nice and let everyone sleep in a bit after the long summit day.

We woke up with the sun and slowly got ready while coffee brewed on the camp stoves. We left camp around 10:30 am.



We took one last look at our lake (which had become rather more crowded while we were out hiking) and headed down the trail.





Along the way we had a good view off in the distance of Half Dome (right) and Starr King (left).



We even made it to the trailhead before dark. How sad is that?

And that was it outside of dinner at a decent Mexican restaurant in Prather and a 6-ish hour drive home. We actually got back to OC at a reasonable 2 am this time.